

CHAPTER 1 — THE MIRROR IN THE SNOW

This is an alternate universe in which Itha Thornwell, the Nightstalker, was discovered wounded and unconscious by Alaric Branwood. Unaware of her true identity, he carried her to his secluded home and nursed her back to health. As the weeks passed, his care grew into closeness, and that closeness became love, changing them both. In the three months they had lived together, Itha had stepped away from her life as the Nightstalker as the warmth of what they shared had grown stronger. Yet beyond the safety of Alaric's home, the hunt for the Nightstalker had never stopped.

Deep within the southern region of Velldenaar, close to the shadow of Mount Aaragath, the Dark Forest lay beneath a pale winter hush.

The trees stood old and heavy, their branches bending beneath the snow and their trunks half-buried in white, while thin sunlight slipped through the pines in cold, narrow beams and touched the frozen ground in quiet patches. Nearby, the river murmured beneath broken ice, soft enough to sound almost gentle, and for a moment the world seemed to possess the kind of stillness that belonged only to untouched winter.

It should have felt peaceful.

Yet the forest was unnaturally quiet, without the chatter of birds, the darting shapes that should have moved among the branches or the smaller creatures stirring beneath the underbrush. Even the familiar creak of pine and the whisper of needles had grown subdued, as though the woods were listening for something that had already happened.

Blood breaks the spell.

At first, there were only scattered marks across the snow, small splashes of red half-covered by the falling white, but farther ahead the stains grew darker and wider, spreading into smears where men had fallen, crawled or been thrown. Boot tracks cut through the clearing in frantic lines, crossing over one another until it was impossible to distinguish where any one man had tried to go.

Beyond them stood the hut.

It rested close to the riverbank, rough and small beneath the pines, its timber walls dark with frost and its roof bent beneath winter's weight. Thin smoke still rose from the chimney, lending it a strange appearance of peace that might have been convincing were it not for the ground in front of it.

A battle had taken place here, and the violence of it had left the clearing almost unrecognizable.

Snowdrifts had been torn open and churned into slush, frozen clumps scattered across the ground like ash, while bark had been ripped from nearby trunks and snapped branches jutted from the snow like broken spears. The woodpile beside the hut had been scattered, and a fence post lay cracked nearby, as though something had struck it with enough force to throw it from the ground.

Bodies lay around the hut in positions that suggested they had been thrown rather than simply cut down. Some had fallen face-first, crumpled as though they had been dropped in the middle of a stride, while others lay farther from the door and walls, out toward the edge of the clearing, where they appeared to have fled before whatever pursued them caught up.

One soldier had been driven against a tree with such force that snow had shaken loose from the branches and buried part of his body. Another lay twisted in a shape no living person could have held, his bones apparently giving way before the rest of him, while farther out the remains of another man had been torn apart with a violence that bore little resemblance to swordwork. His clothing was shredded and his limbs wrenched, leaving behind the ruin of someone whose attacker had cared nothing for precision, only for the outcome.

They had been soldiers of Kalluth, men of the Searing Flame, and even beneath the blood and snow their colors remained unmistakable: black armor, red scarves stitched with gold and tabards bearing the sigil of the Searing Flame they had died serving.

The smell lingered over everything. Blood and iron mingled with sweat trapped in fabric, disturbed earth and torn pine, but beneath those familiar traces of battle lay something more difficult to escape, a thick, sour sense of fear that seemed to cling to the clearing long after the screams themselves had died.

Yet for all the brutality, the strangest thing was what the violence had spared.

The hut stood almost untouched, as though the fighting had been forced to move around it. There were no broad splashes of blood across the timber, no smeared handprints on the planks, and even the threshold, where the worst of the struggle might have been expected, had remained strangely clean. Whatever had happened here had not happened at the door. Again and again the fight appeared to have been pushed outward, away from the walls, as though an invisible line had been drawn through the snow and defended at any cost.

The thing the soldiers had attacked had not been fighting merely to survive.

It had been protecting the hut, holding the violence away from its door with such determination that not even a drop of blood seemed to have reached it.

At the center of the clearing, the final struggle had become almost impossibly quiet.

One man stood behind a masked figure, his body pressed tightly against its back and his arms locked around it, holding it in a grip that left almost nowhere to turn. The figure struggled against him, but he had drawn it so close that slipping to either side or dropping beneath his hold was no longer possible.

The man was Raphael Marchand. Tan skin showed at his throat where his armor did not fully cover him, and his brown hair was damp with melting snow. His wine-dark red eyes remained fixed past the mask, unblinking, as though he had already decided how the struggle will end.

A red cloak hung heavily from his shoulders, vivid against the winter white and fastened at the front on his right side by a golden medal. Whenever the wind shifted, the fabric tugged behind him and a thin slice of sunlight caught his steel before the shadows swallowed it once more.

The Nightstalker wore a long, dark blue cloak heavy with snowmelt, its back lined with thick white fur that appeared almost impossibly soft against the darkness of the figure beneath it. Long blonde hair fell entirely over the front of the body, spilling down both sides in pale lengths that reached nearly to the legs, its muted gold an eerie contrast to the cold colors of the attire.

Beneath the cloak, the sleeves and trousers were black, while the chest of the garment was a deep, subdued blue, bound by a belt. Long black boots disappeared into the snow, and both hands were encased in metal gloves ending in claws that resembled the talons of a hunting beast more than anything fashioned for a human hand.

A bone-white mask concealed the face, shaped into the unsettling likeness of some strange, owl-like creature. From its hollow sockets shone a cold blue light, bright and unnatural, like pupils kindled by a flame trapped beneath frost.

Something else moved beneath the white fur at the back of the cloak.

Bandages spilled from the Nightstalker's back in pale, ragged lengths, hanging in the air as though they had forgotten they were cloth. They coiled and uncoiled with a restless intelligence, searching for space, for purchase and for a place to strike, and every so often one snapped forward in a sharp, eager movement before drawing back again.

Raphael gave them no opening.

He held the Nightstalker folded against him, his forearm locked across the upper chest while his other hand trapped both wrists and pulled the arms down and back. The clawed fingers scraped at empty air, flexing and twitching with a danger that had not diminished simply because their owner was caught, but Raphael kept the joints angled so that the figure could neither turn to rake at him nor pull free without doing terrible damage to its own body.

He planted his feet wide in the churned snow and used the weight of his body to maintain the hold. Pressed between the Nightstalker and his armor, the bandages had little room to move, and though some still writhed over his shoulder and along his side, their blows were reduced to short, frustrated arcs that scraped against the metal with a dry rasp. They remained alive with furious movement, contained only because Raphael refused to give them the space they needed.

When the Inquisitor approached, Raphael did not loosen his hold. He drew the struggling figure closer still.

In front of them stood Prince Nathanos Thornwell, commander of the squad and the Inquisitor assigned to the hunt. Long blond hair fell to his shoulders in loose strands stirred by the wind, framing a face that remained almost too composed for the carnage surrounding him. His skin was smooth and pale, spared the worst of the cold by the quiet inner flame he carried within him, and his blue eyes remained fixed upon the mask with unwavering attention.

He wore a long inquisitor's coat, dark grey with a faint purple cast beneath the winter light, cut for authority as much as combat. A tabard bearing the insignia of the Searing Flame lay across his chest, while a heavy red scarf threaded with gold was wrapped around his neck and shoulders. Thorned guards rose from his shoulders like a crown of dark metal brambles, their golden thorns catching the light whenever he moved.

Even here, surrounded by blood and frost, he held himself with the posture expected of a prince, shoulders straight and hands steady. Fear still worked beneath that composure as his gaze passed over the men who had died under his command, but he could not allow it to make him hesitate now.

He stepped through the wreckage and reached into the churned snow.

A blade lay half-buried at his feet, discarded during the fighting, its edge iced where blood had met the winter cold. Nathanos closed his gloved fingers around the hilt and drew it free, the frozen slush cracking as the steel rose and shed thin sheets of snow. For a heartbeat he held the weapon before him, not to admire it, but to claim it for what remained to be done.

Beneath the leather of his glove, a quiet heat answered the tightening of his grip. He kept his inner flame leashed, allowing no great blaze to engulf the sword and no sudden spectacle to warn the figure struggling before him. Instead, he guided a controlled warmth down his arm and into the metal, until the frost along its length began to sweat and the small beads of moisture vanished from the blade. The steel grew warm enough that the cold would not slow or hinder it when he struck.

For one final, desperate moment, the Nightstalker fought Raphael's grip. The body twisted hard against him and the bandages snapped upward, struggling to drag him away and create even the smallest opening through which their owner might escape.

Raphael held firm.

Nathanos stepped forward, his blue eyes never leaving the mask, and drove the blade into the Nightstalker's chest.

A scream tore through the clearing.

For the first heartbeat, it was not one voice but two, breaking from beneath the mask at once. The first was unmistakably human, the shocked and ragged cry of a woman in pain, while beneath it rose something that seemed ancient and starving, forcing its way through the same throat. The second voice swelled into a shriek too sharp and too vast to belong to anything living, overwhelming the human cry and carrying between the trees until even the forest seemed to recoil from it.

Nathanos froze at the first sound, not because it was human, but because something in it was familiar.

Before he could understand why, the monstrous voice tore through it, crushing whatever recognition had begun to form beneath the horror of the sound.

The Nightstalker's body bucked and then locked, lungs fighting for air that would not come, while Raphael jerked behind the figure as the heated blade passed through and bit into him as well. His eyes squeezed shut, and he swallowed the sound that tried to escape him as pain caught his breath in his throat.

Nathanos stood motionless before them, his own chest rising in a shallow, constricted breath as though the scream had struck him too. His eyes widened behind the certainty he had carried into the fight, while Raphael remained pressed against the figure, his face twisted against the pain and his grip still holding even as the blade pinned them together.

Then, before the Nightstalker died, a smaller sound slipped from beneath the mask.

It was nothing like the terrible, layered scream that had torn through the clearing. This voice was softer and broken, stripped of the beast that had drowned it out, and for one terrible moment Nathanos could hear nothing monstrous in it at all. He heard only a woman, trembling with pain, and the familiar quality of her voice became more difficult to dismiss.

His fingers tightened around the sword. He had to push the thought away, because familiar or not, it could not change what he had done.

He had seen the creature before, though always at a distance, a shape standing at the edge of the trees while its minions, the Nightmares, fought in its place. Whenever his men had pushed close enough to reach it, the shadow had vanished back into the forest, leaving them with little more than the aftermath of its passing. Until now, he had never stood near enough to hear its voice, and he had never imagined that a woman's cry might lie hidden beneath all that dread.

Yet this was the Nightstalker of Velldenar. The reports had named it, survivors had witnessed it, and the corruption left in its wake had tied the creature to the Lord of Dread. Whether it had been born from him, made by him or bound to his will, the signs had led Nathanos and his men here, to the thing they had been ordered to destroy.

This was why people vanished along the roads and from the villages, why families locked their doors before dusk and why the southern region could not rest while the Nightstalker still moved beneath the trees.

It had to be done. Nathanos forced the pity down before it could take root, holding to that certainty because he could not afford to question it now.

Then the mask loosened.

Its straps had slackened during the violent convulsion of the figure's body, and the bone-white face tilted, dragged across a cheek and slipped away. It fell into the snow with a soft sound that seemed impossibly small after the screaming.

For the first time, Nathanos saw the woman's face.

He stared, and for one impossible moment the movement of the entire clearing seemed to fall away. Even the wind passing between the trees appeared to have stopped, leaving him with nothing but the face the mask had concealed.

It was his.

Not merely similar, but identical, from the line of the jaw to the shape of the mouth, the bone and brow. The same features he had known all his life looked back at him from a dying woman he had never seen unmasked, and no part of his mind could make the sight belong to the world around him. His breath caught, his blue eyes fixed upon hers, and he could not bring himself to look away.

Tears gathered along her lashes and spilled down her cheeks, cutting clean tracks through the frost and blood. Her lips trembled, and her gaze drifted past him, past the trees and the ruin of the clearing, as though she were already slipping beyond what stood before her.

With her last breath, she whispered, the words breaking apart before she could finish them.

“I am sorry, Ala... I... I... lov...”

The rest never came.

The light drained from her eyes, and her body grew heavy against Raphael, utterly still with the blade lodged through her chest and into the man who held her. From her back, the pale grey bandages that had fought like additional limbs shuddered once, as though searching for one last command, before the force sustaining them disappeared. They slackened in the air and dropped into the snow in long, lifeless ribbons.

Whatever had animated them was gone with her.

Nathanos moved before he could gather a thought around what he had seen. He pulled the sword free, the motion numb and automatic, without triumph or relief, as though his body still understood what followed a killing even while his mind refused to follow it.

The heated steel left Raphael and then the woman with a wet, steaming hiss. Without the blade to hold her between them, she fell into the snow, her limbs slack and her pale hair spilling against the white as her face turned down into the drift. The mask lay nearby, half-buried, and all around her the fallen bandages remained motionless where they had landed, already gathering frost.

For several heartbeats, Nathanos could do nothing but stare at the place she had fallen. Even when he forced himself to look away, her face remained before him, its impossible likeness refusing to become anything he could understand.

A rough, involuntary sound behind him dragged his attention back to the living.

“Raphael!”

The soldier’s knees buckled. Nathanos turned as the sword slipped from his hand and struck the snow with a muted hiss, its heated edge sinking into the white beside him, and caught Raphael before he could fall. He braced an arm around him and pulled him close, only to see blood pouring from the scorched breach in his armor, dark and fast against the snow.

“Stay with me. Raphael, stay with me.”

Raphael drew a breath through clenched teeth and tried to force a crooked smirk, pride resisting what the weakness in his body made plain. “I’ve had worse.”

“I...” Nathanos began, but the word caught in his throat. He looked from the blood spreading beneath Raphael’s armor to the soldier’s face, struggling to reconcile the familiar man before him with the terrible wound he had caused, and his hands trembled as he tried to decide where to place them.

“Are you out of your mind?” he snapped, his voice carrying more fear than he intended. “I could have killed you, Raphael. Was there no other way?”

Raphael’s mouth tightened against the pain, and the remains of his smirk disappeared. “There wasn’t,” he answered, his voice rough but steady. “You saw how she fought.” His red eyes shifted toward the woman lying face-down in the snow, the limp bandages scattered around her like shed skin. “If I hadn’t taken her from behind, if I hadn’t caught her by surprise, she would’ve killed us all.”

He drew another strained breath before looking back at Nathanos. “She didn’t see me coming because she was fixated on you. That was our only opening.”

Nathanos stared at him, the words reaching him more slowly than they should have. Their only opening had been Raphael standing behind her, holding her still while the blade drove forward, and the same strike that had killed the Nightstalker had torn through him as well. Nathanos could remember the resistance of the weapon, the sound of her scream and the sudden movement of Raphael's body, but none of it explained how he was supposed to accept what his friend had chosen to endure.

Raphael shifted slightly, and fresh blood welled through the breach in his armor.

The sight brought Nathanos back to what mattered. His hand hovered over the wound for another breath, fingers spread as though he feared touching the damage he had done, before he pressed his palm against the scorched metal.

Heat answered at once. He did not summon a blaze or allow his power to escape into the open air, but guided his inner flame into a narrow, deliberate warmth that passed through broken armor and torn flesh. It sealed what it could and slowed the bleeding to a dark ooze, buying Raphael time that the cold and the wound were threatening to take from him.

Nathanos kept his jaw locked and his attention fixed on his work, but when he spoke, the strain remained in his voice.

“This will stop the bleeding,” he said, though a strange resistance beneath his palm made him hesitate. The torn flesh was proving far more difficult to close than it should have been, resisting his flame despite his efforts to seal it. “But I’m having trouble closing the wound completely. We have to get you to Kalluth as soon as possible for proper treatment. My flame can only seal so much.”

He glanced across the clearing, his breath growing uneven as he took in the bodies scattered through the drifts, one man after another who had followed him into the forest and would never rise again. Leaving them here felt impossible, yet Raphael shifted against him, too heavy and far too warm with the blood he was losing, and Nathanos pressed his hand harder against the wound as though that pressure alone might keep him alive.

“We can come back,” he said, more quietly now, the words coming faster as he tried to make himself believe them. “Later. We’ll bury them. We won’t leave them like this. But not now. Not while you’re...”

He could not bring himself to finish the thought.

Raphael watched him while the heat continued working beneath his hand, feeling the tremor in Nathanos’s fingers and hearing the way his breathing failed to settle. Nathanos had never been the shining hero sung about in taverns, but he was no coward, and Raphael had fought beside him long enough to know that the fear now breaking through his composure was not simply fear of battle.

Something deeper had taken hold of him.

Despite the pain, Raphael reached out and gripped Nathanos's forearm, holding it firmly enough to draw his attention back. For that moment, there was little left of the distance between soldier and commander, only one friend trying to keep another from losing himself amid the ruin.

"My prince," he said softly. "Breathe. Focus."

Nathanos dragged air into his lungs and nodded without looking up.

Raphael gathered what strength he could into his voice. "Listen to me. Today we became true heroes."

Nathanos looked at him, startled by the certainty of the words, and Raphael inclined his head toward the fallen men, toward the torn bodies half-buried in the snow and the ruin the Nightstalker had left behind.

"She wasn't just an enemy," Raphael continued, his voice low and rough. "She was a fiend, a monster given flesh. An incarnation of dread." His gaze traveled across the clearing. "You saw what she did, how she didn't only kill. She broke them. Drove men into madness with the horror. Made them beg for death before it came."

His mouth tightened when he found the bodies of their own squad. Blood had crusted dark upon the snow around them, and the men who had been fighting at his side only moments earlier lay with their faces emptied of everything he had known in them. Grief cut through his pride, leaving his next words quieter.

“Even if it cost the lives of our remaining men,” he said, “they didn’t die for nothing.”

Nathanos swallowed, but the words Raphael had used remained lodged in his thoughts.

Fiend. Dread. Monster.

Only moments ago, he might have repeated them without hesitation. Now he saw the woman’s face again, the same face as his own, appearing so clearly in his mind that for an instant he could scarcely distinguish the memory from the man standing before him. The Dark Forest seemed to be placing that impossible likeness before him again and again, until the horror was no longer confined to what he had killed. If the hatred surrounding the Nightstalker belonged to a face identical to his, then some frightened part of him could not stop wondering whether that same hatred might just as easily have been turned upon him.

His breath caught and his spine stiffened, his eyes widening while his gaze drifted away from Raphael and settled upon nothing he could name.

Raphael felt the change immediately. He did not understand what Nathanos had seen beneath the mask or what thought had carried him so far from the clearing, but he recognized the danger of letting him retreat into himself while they were still surrounded by the dead.

He tried to draw Nathanos closer with his good arm, bracing him in the churned snow, and pain tore through his abdomen the moment he shifted his weight. A low grunt escaped him before he could stop it, and fresh blood welled from the wound Nathanos had only just sealed.

His balance failed. Nathanos caught the movement and tightened his hold around him, guiding their descent as carefully as he could until they sank into the snow together. Raphael ended half-braced against him, breathing unevenly, while Nathanos kept one arm locked around his friend and his other hand pressed against the wound.

Still, Raphael refused to let go of him.

“Nathanos,” he murmured, his voice firm despite the effort it cost him. “She can’t hurt us anymore. Do you hear me? The madness is over.”

Nathanos tried to steady his breathing, but it broke again before he could draw a full breath.

Raphael tightened his grip around his arm and spoke more quietly, with less of the certainty he had tried to summon on the battlefield and more of the concern he could no longer conceal.

“Do not let her feeble madness corrupt your mind,” he said. “We did it. The hunt for the Nightstalker is finally over.” His fingers pressed more firmly into Nathanos’s sleeve. “I need you here, Nathanos. Focused. More than ever.”

Nathanos blinked, and the clearing returned to him in pieces. He saw the snow beneath them, the river beyond the hut, the men scattered through the drifts and Raphael’s red cloak gathering white along its folds. His eyes passed briefly over the woman lying motionless in the snow before settling upon the wound beneath his hand.

Fresh blood was seeping through the scorched breach in Raphael’s armor, slower than before but still far too much, darkening the space beneath Nathanos’s palm and threatening to undo what he had forced closed only moments earlier.

He pressed his hand back against the damaged metal, spreading his fingers over the wound and allowing his inner flame to answer again. The heat came sharper this time, urgent but controlled, and Nathanos fixed his attention upon it, concentrating on the torn flesh and the bleeding rather than allowing his thoughts to return to the face beneath the mask.

Raphael sucked in a breath as the warmth worked through him. His eyes squeezed shut and a rough sound escaped his throat, but Nathanos kept his hand in place until the flow of blood began to slow once more.

For a while neither man spoke. Only the winter wind moved around them, carrying the soft hiss of the flame as it worked beneath Nathanos's palm.

Then Raphael opened his eyes and looked across the battlefield.

He could almost hear the screams again, the voices of men driven beyond themselves as the Nightstalker's madness worked through their minds. He remembered soldiers turning their blades upon the air, upon one another and even upon their own throats, their faces contorted with terror and confusion until some had died without knowing whose hand held the weapon that took them.

Nathanos had been there for all of it. He had watched his own men, the soldiers under his command, torn apart while he fought the thing responsible.

Raphael understood something of his shock then, though not the full shape of whatever had trapped Nathanos behind those haunted eyes. Perhaps the horrors of Drathmoor had returned to him, the memories of that terrible siege resurfacing after everything he had witnessed here. Raphael could understand the weight of the men they had lost, and he could at least try to keep their memory from becoming another reason for his prince to lose himself.

"Kenneth," Raphael said suddenly, his voice rough.

Nathanos did not look up. His palm remained pressed against the wound, the heat beneath it narrowing into careful, deliberate purpose.

“Marren. Joric. Halven.” Raphael kept his eyes upon the fallen, grief pressing through the pain.

“They fought bravely. Every one of them. Kenneth especially. Young as he was, he stood fiercer than men twice his age.”

Nathanos’s jaw tightened, but he said nothing.

“They were part of this victory. All of them,” Raphael continued, drawing another shallow breath. “Their names will be carried back to Kalluth with ours. The people will remember what they gave here. Kalluth will remember. The southern region of Velldengar will remember.” His voice grew rougher, though he fought to keep it steady. “They will know peace because of their sacrifice.”

Nathanos continued working over the wound, focusing on the blood and on forcing the torn flesh to close beneath his hand. Raphael watched him for a moment longer before speaking again.

“And your father will know it too.”

Nathanos’s hand stilled.

Raphael turned his eyes back to him, holding his gaze despite the color draining from his own face. “King Aren Thornwell will hear that the Nightstalker is dead. He will hear that the south can be held again, that the tide of this war has shifted because of what you did here.” His grip tightened weakly around Nathanos’s arm. “He will see it, Nathanos. He will see you.”

Slowly, Nathanos lifted his gaze.

The horror of what he had seen remained, along with the guilt and the terrible confusion that had followed the mask’s fall, but Raphael’s words had reached something beneath them. For years Nathanos had carried a hunger that training and discipline had never managed to satisfy, a longing for the approval of the father whose recognition he had sought through every difficult step of his life.

Approval. Recognition. Family.

Raphael saw the moment that hope reached him, however uncertainly, and Nathanos drew in a shaky breath before returning his attention to the wound.

“If you keep talking like that, you won’t live long enough to hear what he says,” Nathanos muttered.

A faint smirk tugged at Raphael's mouth despite the pain. "There you are," he murmured.

"Welcome back, Nathanos."

The flame beneath Nathanos's palm steadied for a final time, sealing the worst of the wound until the blood slowed to a dark, stubborn seep. It had not healed Raphael, and Nathanos knew that whatever damage lay deeper inside him remained beyond what he could safely mend here, but the wound was held together well enough that they might be able to move.

He exhaled and lifted his hand only slightly, keeping it close in case the bleeding began again.

"Are you ready to move?" he asked.

Raphael gave a small, strained nod. "As ready as I'll ever be."

Nathanos forced himself upright, his legs stiff with cold and shock, and hooked an arm beneath Raphael's to help him rise. The soldier came to his feet with a sharp, uneven breath, his arm sliding heavily over Nathanos's shoulder while most of his weight settled against his prince. Nathanos tightened his grip around him and waited until Raphael had found what little footing he could.

Together, they began the slow journey away from the ruin. The hut remained behind them, along with the woman lying face-down in the snow and the silence that seemed to have settled over the clearing to watch them leave.

There was nothing they could do for the dead now, not with Raphael still bleeding and their strength running thin, but Nathanos could not allow himself to believe they would be left there forever. He would return to bury the men who had followed him into the forest and give them something better than a grave of blood and snow.

Raphael swallowed a strained breath and glanced over his shoulder.

“Don’t leave it,” he muttered. “The mask.”

Nathanos hesitated, his body resisting the thought of turning back even as he understood what duty demanded.

“We’ll need proof,” Raphael added. “Kalluth won’t take stories. Not without something to show.”

The words cut through the fog in Nathanos's thoughts. He nodded and carefully shifted Raphael's weight against his shoulder, keeping one arm locked around him while he reached down toward the snow.

He kept his eyes averted from the woman's body as his fingers closed around the bone-white mask. It was cold and damp, its carved grooves darkened by melting flakes, and he refused to look at it any longer than he needed to before threading it onto his belt.

It hung against his side when they began moving again, proof to carry back to Kalluth and a reminder of what had happened in the clearing, whether either of them wished to remember it or not.

Raphael leaned heavily upon him as they made their way toward the place where the horses waited beyond the trees. Each step remained uneven, each breath dragged through pain, but Nathanos bore most of his weight and kept them moving, unwilling to stop while the wound might open again.

Before the forest took the clearing from sight, Nathanos allowed himself one last look at the place they had left behind.

From a distance, the ruin looked almost peaceful. Snow continues to drift in slow spirals through the pale sunlight, gathering along the branches while the river murmured beneath its ice as though nothing had happened. There was something unbearable about that quiet, about a small and seemingly serene stretch of wilderness that had held the Nightstalker, swallowed the screams of his men and now offered no witness to what it had taken from them.

The snowfall grew heavier, settling upon Nathanos's shoulders and within the folds of Raphael's red cloak. Behind them, it gathered over broken armor, still hands and the bodies of soldiers who had followed their prince into the Dark Forest and would not follow him home.

It fell upon the woman as well, upon the pale hair spread across the snow and the motionless figure Velldendar had known only as the Nightstalker.

Nathanos turned his eyes away from her. He could not bring himself to look at that face again, the face that no one else had seen beneath the mask, and which now belonged to him alone. The world would know the Nightstalker by the bone-white mask he carried at his side, but Nathanos would carry something far more terrible, the knowledge of her true face, identical to his own, a truth he could neither understand nor escape.

He fixed his attention upon the trees ahead, upon the waiting horses and the narrow way that would eventually lead them back to Kalluth, holding instead to the words Raphael had given him.

Hero. Justice. Victory.

With a heavy heart, he carried his friend onward while the snow settled over the living and the dead alike, gentle as a blessing and cold as a shroud.

At his side, the bone-white mask moved against his belt with every step, proof for Kalluth and a weight he would never truly leave behind.